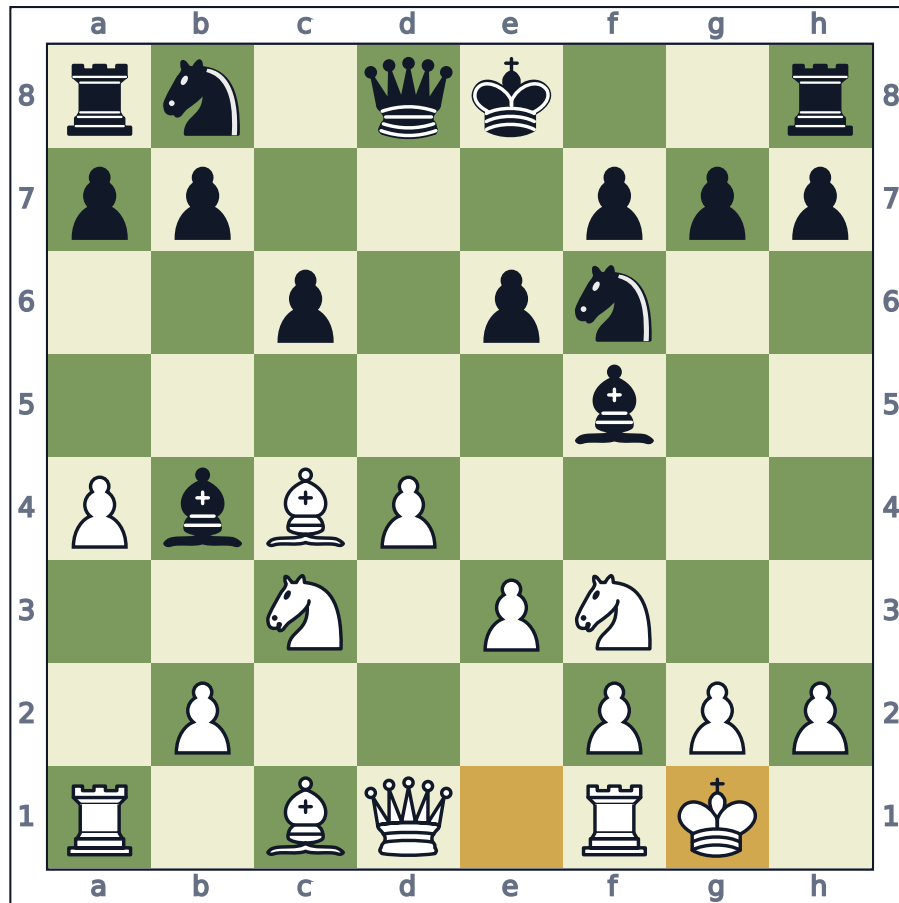


Slav Defense

A ground-up visual course for practical play



Core route position - gold marks the last move

BOTH SIDES

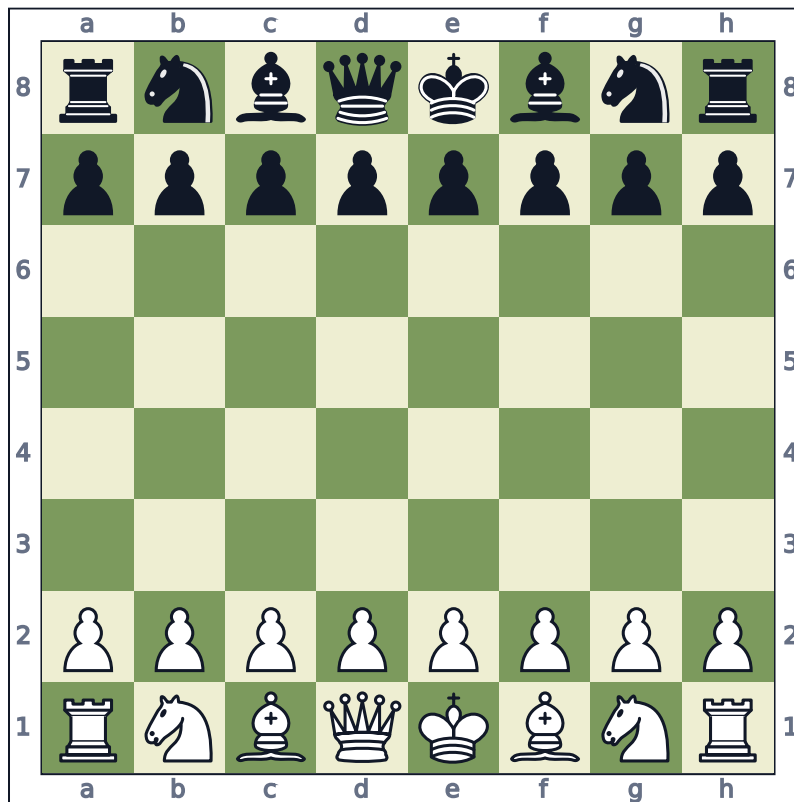
OPENING IDENTITY

Black supports d5 with ...c6 while leaving the light bishop free.

ORIENTATION

Ground zero: read the board and the moves

White starts from ranks 1-2; Black starts from ranks 7-8. Files run a through h. Each lesson highlights the last move in gold so your eyes connect notation to the board.



Starting position - White to move

HOW ALGEBRAIC NOTATION WORKS

Nf3 means a knight moves to f3. B means bishop, R rook, Q queen, K king; pawns use only the destination square. An x means capture, + means check, and O-O means kingside castling.

YOUR FIRST ANCHOR

Say the first moves aloud, then point to every destination square:

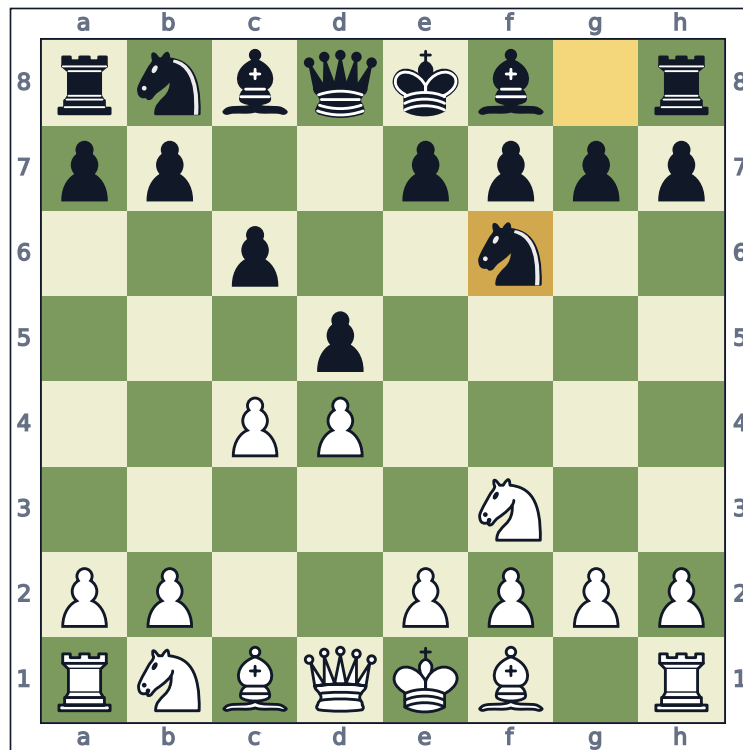
1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6

Course promise: Support d5 without locking in the bishop.

MOVES 1-3

Lesson 1: the first conversation

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6



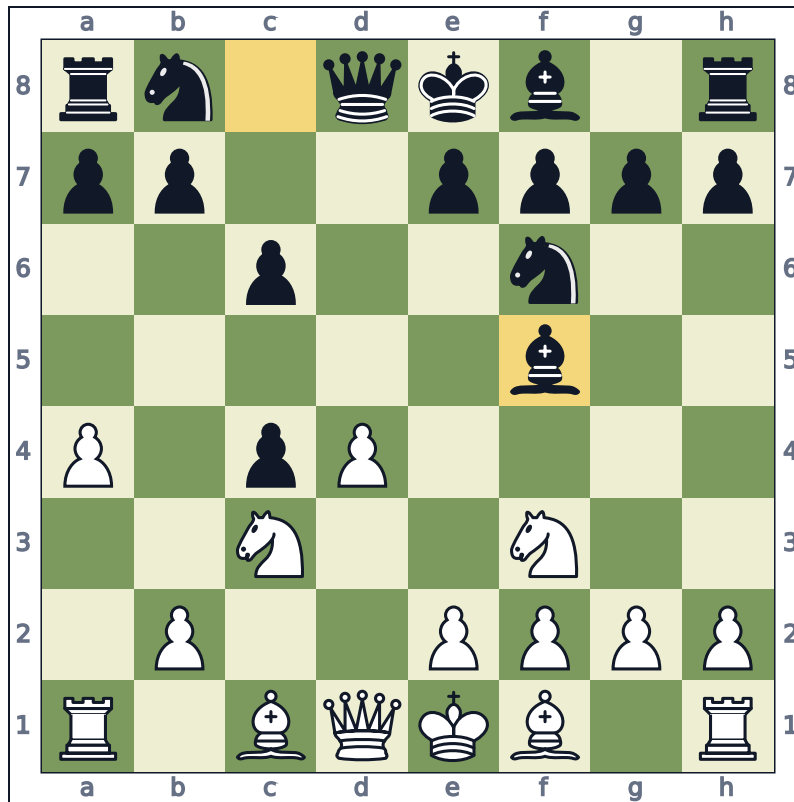
After 3. Nf3 Nf6

- 1. d4 - Claims or challenges central space and opens a line for a piece.
- 1... d5 - Claims or challenges central space and opens a line for a piece.
- 2. c4 - Creates a lever against the center or supports a coming break.
- 2... c6 - Creates a lever against the center or supports a coming break.
- 3. Nf3 - Develops a knight toward the center and increases control of key central squares.
- 3... Nf6 - Develops a knight toward the center and increases control of key central squares.

DEVELOPMENT

Lesson 2: build the core position

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 dxc4 5. a4 Bf5

**WHAT THE PIECES ARE BUILDING**

Black supports d5 with ...c6 while leaving the light bishop free.

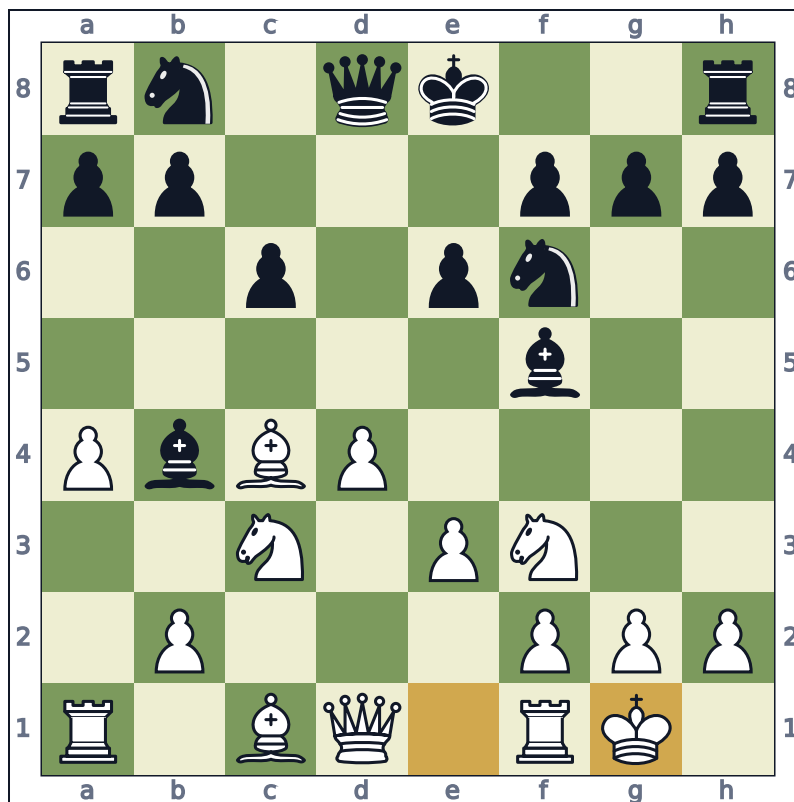
BEGINNER CHECKPOINT

Before copying the next move, ask: Is my king safe? Which piece is still at home? What changed in the center? Which pawn break is each side preparing?

CORE LINE

Lesson 3: complete the main route

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 dxc4 5. a4 Bf5 6. e3 e6 7. Bxc4 Bb4 8. O-O



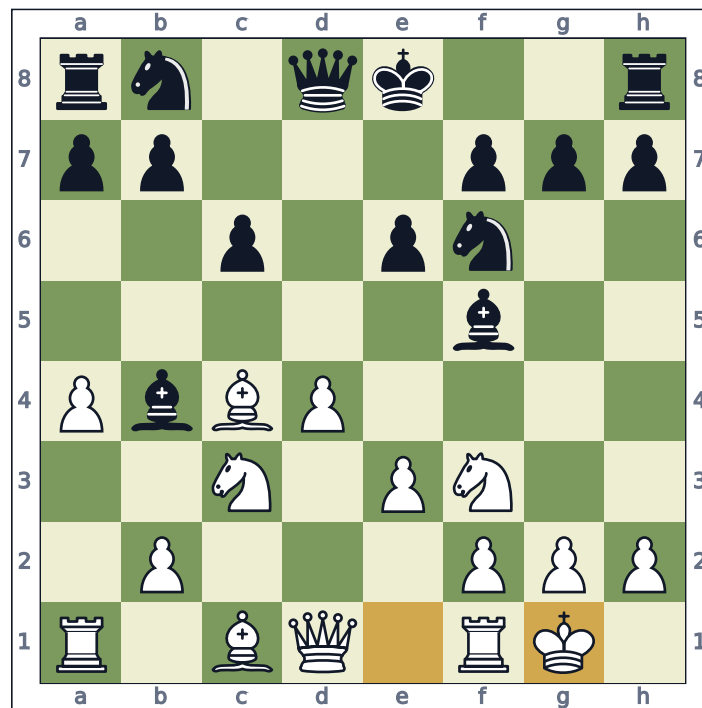
Core position - now plans matter more than memorized moves

DO NOT MEMORIZE BLINDLY

The route is a model, not a forced script. Its job is to teach this relationship: Black supports d5 with ...c6 while leaving the light bishop free. If the opponent deviates, preserve the same priorities until a concrete tactic changes them.

UNDERSTANDING

The position map: plans for both sides



Read plans from the pawn structure, not from the opening name

WHITE'S PLAN

Develop, recover c4 efficiently, and use e4 when the center permits it.

BLACK'S PLAN

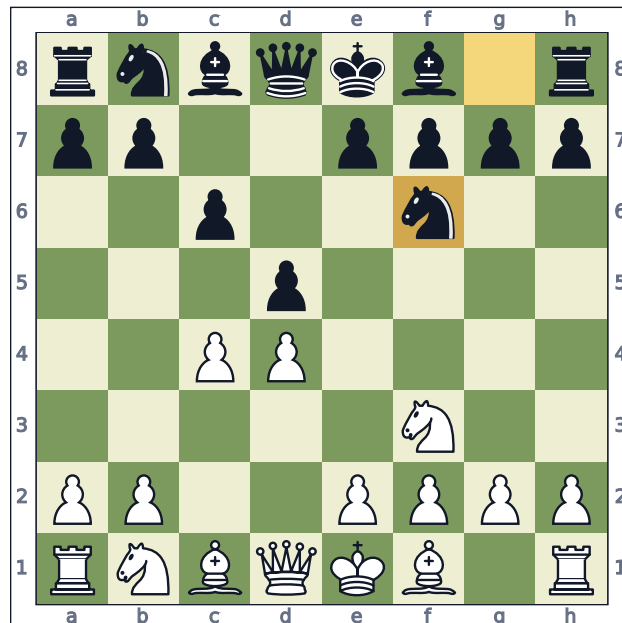
Develop the bishop before ...e6, decide whether to hold c4 briefly, and challenge the center.

THE LEVER TO REMEMBER

Black's ...c5 or ...e5 is the long-term freeing goal.

ADAPTATION

Decision tree: when the opponent leaves the route



A branch point - principles are your map

1. If the center stays fluid

Finish development and keep the opening identity in view: Black supports d5 with ...c6 while leaving the light bishop free.

2. If the center closes

Use the pawn-chain direction. Attack the base before making wing moves that cannot be supported.

3. If the center opens

Prioritize king safety, active pieces, and checks or captures before slow pawn moves.

4. If nothing is forced

Return to the planned lever: Black's ...c5 or ...e5 is the long-term freeing goal.

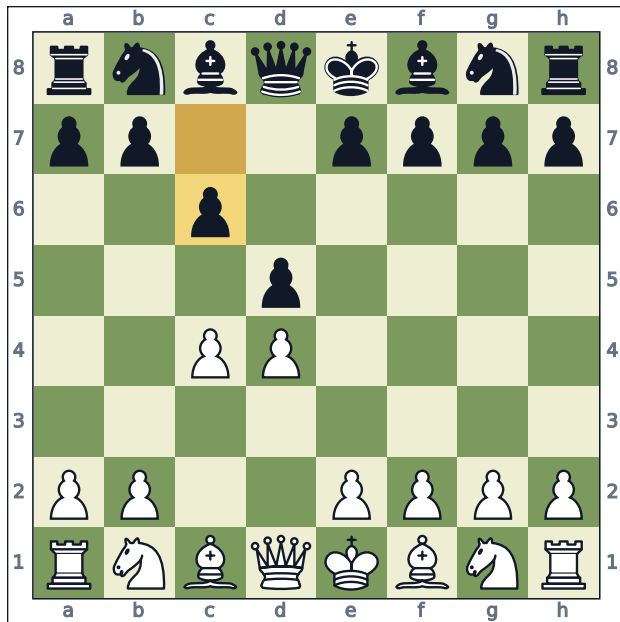
MEMORY SENTENCE

Support d5 without locking in the bishop.

ACTIVE RECALL

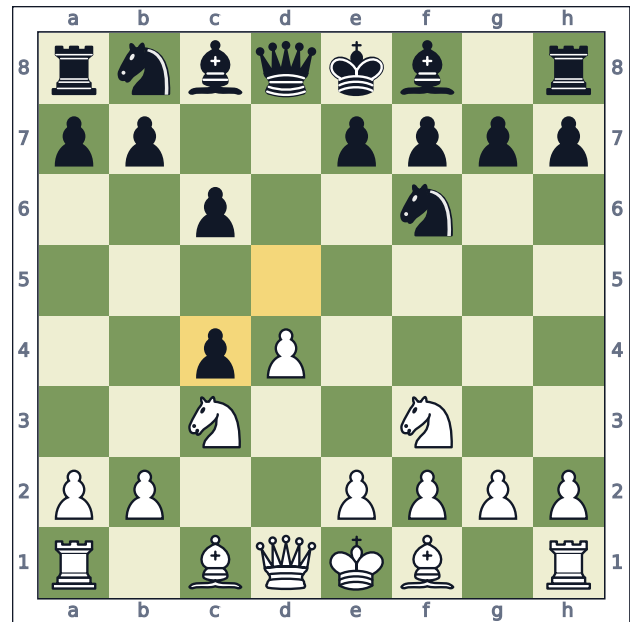
Recall test: answer before you turn the page

POSITION A



White to move

POSITION B



White to move

- A1. What is the next route move for White?
- A2. What opening problem does that move solve?
- B1. What is the next route move for White?
- B2. Name one plan for White and one plan for Black.
- C. State the thematic pawn break without looking back.

SCORING

5/5: replay from memory. 3-4/5: review Lessons 3 and 6. 0-2/5: return to Lesson 1 and rebuild the route slowly.

RETENTION

Answer key and a 14-day practice loop

POSITION A

Next route move: Nf3. Explain it using development, center, king safety, or a direct tactical need.

POSITION B

Next route move: a4. Then compare the position with the final core board.

PLAN AND BREAK ANSWERS

White: Develop, recover c4 efficiently, and use e4 when the center permits it. Black: Develop the bishop before ...e6, decide whether to hold c4 briefly, and challenge the center. Lever: Black's ...c5 or ...e5 is the long-term freeing goal.

14-DAY LOOP

- Days 1-2: replay the first three moves from both sides and name each move's job.
- Days 3-4: build the core position from memory; correct the first error, then restart.
- Days 5-6: say White's plan, Black's plan, and the pawn break without a board.
- Day 7: take the recall test. Record the score; do not count lucky guesses.
- Days 8-10: play three slow practice games, starting from the core position if possible.
- Days 11-13: review only mistakes and deviations that actually occurred in your games.
- Day 14: retake the test and write a one-sentence opening rule in your own words.